

Social Media in the News

The internet has rapidly developed in the past 50 years. The first day of 1983 is widely considered the birth of the internet with the roll out of a communication protocol referred to as Transfer Control Protocol/Internet Protocol (TCP/IP), establishing that all networks be connected by a universal language (University System of Georgia, 2024). In the past 50 years, the computer and internet have both rapidly developed and changed. Through the years of the internet's development, usage of data has become a central conversation, particularly in relation to discussions of cloud networks and data harvesting through various applications, or "apps". The internet today amasses very large amounts of data and legislation governing the usage and leverage of this data continues to be piecemeal. Currently, the United States does not have a comprehensive privacy law but has enacted various sector-specific privacy and data security laws at both the federal and state levels (DLA, 2024). This leads to questions such as, what does appropriate privacy law look like? How much data should a sovereign nation be allowed to collect about its constituents? Or should individual government agencies be able to share data or be able to create a centralized repository?

This short essay focuses on the ethics of government handling of individuals data, particularly focusing on the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) and its creation of a data lake, or centralized repository, in collaboration with the Department of Homeland Security (DHS). WIRED released an article mid-March of this year detailing the creation of this data lake and its intended use in identifying and surveilling immigrants. The United States Customs and Immigration Services (USCIS) has operated a data lake with DHS prior to DOGE, but since DOGE's creation, the agency has been instrumental in uploading massive amounts of data from agencies that were not previously associated with USCIS data collection, such as the Internal Revenue Service (IRS), Social Security Administration (SSA), and voting data from states such as Pennsylvania and Florida. Government agencies do share data, but the process is documented and has limits for specific purposes. President Trump has signed an executive order that requires agencies to facilitate "both the intra- and inter-agency sharing and consolidation of unclassified agency records", while suggesting centralizing all government data into a single repository (Kelly and Elliott, 2025). Sources have told WIRED that connecting the IRS's Palantir System with the

ICE system at DHS would be quite easy, which would allow staff members to query data from both systems at the same time. Many errors can be created in trying to match various datasets, Elizabeth Laid, the director of equity in civic technology at the Center for Democracy and Technology stated,

“I think it’s hard to overstate what a significant departure this is and the reshaping of longstanding norms and expectations that people have about what the government does with their data. You have false positives, and you have false negatives. But in this case, you know, a false positive where you’re saying someone should be targeted for deportation” (Kelly and Elliott, 2025).

This potential for “administrative errors” is very real, as currently there is outrage mounting around the deportation of Kilmar Abrego Garcia, a Salvadorian national who was mistakenly deported due to one of these “errors”; however, the Trump administration refuses to bring him back to the United States, defying a Supreme Court ruling.

There is a shift globally of policymaking being data informed to being data driven, facilitating the need for a global perspective on the just use of digital data. Linnet Taylor’s article “What is data justice?” proposes a concept of *data justice* being necessary to determine ethical decisions in a “datifying” world (Taylor, 2017). She notes that the impacts of big data are incredibly different depending on one’s socio-economic position. Some of these impacts include surveillance methods focusing on the poor, focus of bureaucratic systems that are designed to assure that people are not misusing state welfare funds or other publicly funded support, data-driven law enforcement, and invasive tracking of undocumented migrants in ways not seen by high income tourists. She writes, “The public-private interact involved in large-scale data collection, and it’s inevitable engagement with the global data market, raise fundamental questions about how rights can be secured across borders and legal systems, and even about whether individual rights should be the only instrument used to combat data harms” (Taylor, 2017). Linnet’s writing very accurately encapsulates a lot of the ethical issues that are presented with DOGE’s creation of a massive database that has a main goal of surveil and tracking immigrants. While this centralized database is being created with the focus of undocumented immigrants, generally referred to as “aliens” within these departments, but would have widespread applications for law enforcement that is driven by data. Police have collected data in concerning fashion for years and are pivoting towards AI to make “data-informed” policing decisions. Police collect visual surveillance, forensic data

terminals, DNA databases and are often making deals with data vendors and brokers to surveil people they already view as suspects. Barry Friedman of the Stanford Constitutional Law Center notes that this is unconstitutional under the Fourth Amendment, which protects against “unreasonable searches and seizures”. This prompts further conversations of bans versus regulation regarding this sort of collection of data (Porteous, 2025).

Elizabeth Laid’s statement regarding the mismatching of datasets that were not created in tandem producing queries that are false positives or negatives has the potential to fuel misinformation being espoused by the Trump administration (Kelly and Elliott, 2025). One lie that is told by the administration is that illegal immigrants are voting American elections illegally at alarming rates that could throw elections completely. This idea has been thoroughly disproven; however, by utilizing this DOGE database could manipulate data to create this illusion. The Trump administration also constantly paints immigrants as rapists, drug dealers, and murderers, but studies have repeatedly shown that higher percentages of immigrants does not show greater incidence of crime and in cases of homicide convictions both legal immigrants and undocumented immigrants are the least likely to be found guilty, with Native-born Americans as the most often convicted of murder (Charen, 2025). All of these lies boil down to the creation of disinformation, which is “information that is likely to create false beliefs”, a process that is non-accidental. There is a function in the process as the distinguishing feature of disinformation is that its function is the mislead people (Fallis, 2015). The use of utilizing massive datasets inappropriately to provide false evidence of lies being told about various groups of people, immigrants in particular, can showcase problems within the population regarding media literacy. Stanford university has noted that students do not have a keen ability to access online information, which researchers have noted is a “bleak” trend that is a “threat to democracy”. Educators have also stressed the need for teaching media literacy to the general population, emulating programs that were popular post-WWII to counter the effects of propaganda on the public. These programs, however, often get caught up in ideological firestorms over the facts that students are supposed to be learning to discern (Nunberg, 2021).

For the newly created Department of Governmental Efficiency to spearhead to consolidation of government datasets with little parameters to facilitate the surveillance of

individuals within the United States, whether to track undocumented immigrants or other reasons, will have major ramifications regarding everyone's privacy. The administration will say that it is exclusively used to target "dangerous immigrants"; however, information regarding every individual within the U.S. will make its way into this database. Compounded with the likelihood of queried results creating false positives and negatives, every individual now is potentially going to be targeted, whether that becomes a noted "administrative error" or not, there are likely huge problems that will arise. In one instance the DHS sent an email to Nicole Micheroni, a Massachusetts based, Native-born immigration attorney that warned her to "depart the US immediately", even though removing US citizens is illegal (Levine, 2025). Nicole is educated on these matters and has the resources to fight back, what about when individuals do not have the resources to stand up for themselves? There are also reports that the Trump administration is now attempting to deport immigrants and refugees, regardless of country of origin, to countries such as Ukraine, Libya, and Rwanda. Many of the proposed countries to send deportees are currently in active armed conflicts (Crosse, 2025). There are so many potential problems arising from centralized surveillance programs and the creation of a police-state without any parameters or legal processes. There needs to be a push for data justice by the entire population and the current administration needs to face consequences if they continue deporting individuals without fair trials.

Citations:

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